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COMPANY DEEP-DIVE

Co-Founder at Duvo AI Believes Enterprise AI Automation Holds Significant Potential in Retail and FMCG Sectors

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SMART SUMMARY

Summary

The interview covers the expert's experience building and scaling an enterprise AI automation platform, focusing on process discovery, automation use cases, pricing strategies, and lessons learned from targeting large retail and FMCG clients.

EXPERT BACKGROUND

- Over 10 years of experience in startups, including pharma healthcare (company acquired by IQVIA) and retail (helped transform Rohlik Group into an AI-first company).
- Co-founded an AI automation platform startup focused on automating manual tasks for enterprise companies, particularly in retail and FMCG sectors.
- Experience in scaling AI solutions to enterprise clients, raising significant early-stage funding, and developing partnerships with consulting and implementation firms.

EXPERT SENTIMENT

- Believes there is **significant untapped opportunity in helping enterprises** map and automate processes at scale, especially in retail and FMCG.
- Confident in the business model of combining process discovery with automation, and sees a future in hybrid service/software companies.
- Advocates for a focused approach on specific industries and processes, and sees outcome-based pricing as the optimal model for enterprise AI automation.

TAKEAWAYS

- Initial go-to-market strategy involved experimenting with different industries, but focus was later narrowed to retail and FMCG for greater impact and efficiency.
- Process mapping and discovery tools were key entry points for enterprise clients, often sold as a platform subscription or bundled service, with pricing evolving from free pilots to paid pilots and then to platform and execution-based fees.
- Successful use cases centered on automating supply chain, finance, and commercial processes, with particular value in supply chain automation, invoice processing, and master data correction.
- Partnerships with consulting firms (including Big Four and McKinsey/BCG) were instrumental in accessing clients and validating the platform's value proposition.
- Pricing models evolved from platform fees to workflow/execution-based pricing, with a focus on aligning costs to business outcomes and ROI, and leveraging existing consulting budgets within client organizations.

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Expert Bio

Co-founder at Duvo AI. The expert can speak to their experience setting client pricing during their time as a co-founder, a process they were heavily involved in before transitioning away from day-to-day operations. Additionally, they can provide insights from a client-facing perspective, having interacted directly with clients regarding solution pricing. Co-founder at Duvo, responsible for client-side operations and end-to-end project implementation, working closely with customers to transform business processes and deliver automation solutions that improve efficiency and scalability across organisations.

Interview Transcript

Client 00:00:00

Hi. Thanks for taking the time to talk with me. I am interested in learning more aboutAi companies. Can you share a brief overview of your background?

Expert 00:00:10

I spent around 10 years in startups. First, it was in pharma healthcare, then it was sold to IQVIA. I moved to retail, spent two years with the founder of Rohlik Group, and together we transformed Rohlik to AI first company. Based on that, we founded a startup, Duvo. We raised $16 million in pre-seed and seed, and **we were able to scale to enterprise companies**. We focus on building the platforms that automate manual tasks across enterprise systems and build it for the business people. Recently, I moved out from active founder role and I'm focusing now on a lot to automate companies and help them to transform to AI world, to use the right tools and apply the right principles and so on.

Client 00:00:58

Nice. Super interesting. Very relevant background, I'd say. We were super curious to understand when you guys started and/or the first or last to come, what are the first use cases that you normally pick off, and is it normally you picking off the use cases or do your customers already know what they want? If they don't know what they want, how do you get there?

Expert 00:01:20

The whole vision is still building a layer in the enterprise company, a generic layer you can apply in any kind of industry. We first were getting design partners from different industries, but we deliberately focus on enterprises which have a system which we knew that it's core for learn how to automate enterprise processes. We picked companies like SAP, who own SAP, who own some weird internal admin systems without API and so on. Eventually, in a couple of months, we realized that we need to narrow the scope, and we decided to focus only on retail and FMCG because there is a great narrative around us. We were operator in retail. **Rohlik is very successful as a technological player** as well. We knew what are the pain points in the company.

For us, we already knew where are the pain points and we knew which teams probably bears a lot of opportunities to save. It was a lot about the maturity of the mindset in the company. We started with some design partners in retail, and we focused on supply chain, finance, and commercial, and then we were coming to other enterprises and basically trying to sell the similar use cases. Through the discussions, we quickly realized whether they are mature enough or we need to focus on something else. Through the debates with the clients, we realized that we need to build another feature, which is called Clarity, which is like a AI consultant, which helps to map the processes on scale and tell company how their processes looks like and where are the opportunities to automate. Because companies sometimes don't know.

Client 00:03:00

How did you qualify whether a customer was a good fit? What was your core criteria, and when did you qualify out?

Expert 00:03:08

I would say, originally, we were trying different sizes. We also launched some product led motion, so like a self-serve. We also tried some SMEs and stuff, but eventually we realized this is not the right fit. We focus on large enterprises, like 500 people plus, billion revenue plus, which doesn't know what Claude is, or they are not using Claude code, which was some sort of proxy indicator for the maturity of the company.

Client 00:03:38

Did you have a qualification criteria in the first call where you could assess whether they're ready for you or not? Did you want people that were more ready? Did you want people that were less ready? In hindsight, if you now were to start again, how would you qualify the right people to work with, because there's many businesses out there that you could in theory work with. The hard bit is to pick the ones that actually matter.

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Expert 00:04:04
Originally, we tried to get everyone in, so it was more like a people business. We were meeting people. Tomas has a great network in the region, so we were meeting the management team, CEO, CIO in the companies. We were basically able to make a deal with them. If I'm looking back, I would keep the same, 500 people, internal IT department, and leadership is willing to make a change. I think that's important. The CEO and CFO needs to be aligned.

Client 00:04:38
How did you test that normally, whether they're ready to make a change?

Expert 00:04:42
We usually had the interview with them, and we were trying to test how they think about changing their department and if they are willing to touch the core processes or they just have in mind to save time of the people, augment them, so we can deliver the value. We were also checking how big certain teams are. If they have a large commercial team or a large supply chain team or large finance team, basically, it's an opportunity to deliver some extra value.

Client 00:05:11
Understand. You mentioned you then make a deal with CEO, CIO. What does making a deal look like at the start? What did it mean when you just built the product? How did you get in, and what would you do differently?

Expert 00:05:26
Originally, we were trying to get in through some paid pilot, paid POC. We were experimenting with different setups. For example, we originally did a free POC, two-week scope. With some commitment to two-week.

Client 00:05:41
Free or paid?

Expert 00:05:43
One POC. Free of charge. With some commitment to pay. We moved to a paid POC, usually eight weeks process, with the commitment to continue. The price of POC would roll out to the first payment after the agreement. Basically, they would save the money from the POC if they would continue.

Client 00:06:09
How much was the paid POC?

Expert 00:06:11
It was like around €30,000 back then.

Client 00:06:14
How did you roll into an actual contract then?

Expert 00:06:18
We were trying to sign the contract upfront that if we meet some success criteria, we continue. That was the strategy.

Client 00:06:26
Makes sense. Cool.

Expert 00:06:28
We then moved to a different strategy when we developed the tool, which is mapping the processes. That the wedge to the company was actually, let's help you to understand how your company operate, and you don't need expensive consultants or months to map. Use our tool.

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We will help you. You pay around €30,000, and then we will pick a product or process which you can automate.

Client 00:06:55

What do you think worked best?

Expert 00:06:58

I think a lot of companies are just not ready yet for a real AI automation. Also, I think for certain heavy processes, the AI space, business space still needs some time to develop. A good strategy was to help them to map processes first and work with them.

Client 00:07:16

With the pilot, how did you sell the product? Did you just have a 30,000 pilot or did you say, "Hey, you are going to pay seat-based for the product and per workflow mapped, you are going to pay something"?

Expert 00:07:29

Exactly. We basically were selling a yearly-subscription for them to map the processes, and there was some amount of processes mapped. Originally, I think we were selling just a yearly-subscription, and have a web wedge to talk to them and become their partner.

Client 00:07:43

Where does the €30,000 then land? Was it still a €30,000 kick-off project, we help you and then you continue, or?

Expert 00:07:53

No. We were able to sell much higher prices, €60,000+ for the Clarity.

Client 00:08:00

If I recap that, you pivoted from initially a free pilot to then a paid pilot with a contract afterwards to implement thing to then saying, "We are now actually going to sell our platform purely for use case discovery." That was not a pilot product, but it was just, "Hey, you are going to pay €60,000 and you just have the platform." And/or was it assisted workflow mapping?

Expert 00:08:24

Yeah. The proposition was easier to sell, and you still have a wedge to then show them certain workflows, pick the one which you are confident to automate fast and you continue the discussion.

Client 00:08:36

Just to clarify, was it assisted workflow finding, or was it just giving them a tool out of the box?

Expert 00:08:43

It depended. We offered also paid services, so we teach them how to do it. It depended on the company, if they wanted assisted mapping or they wanted to use the tool by themselves. Still, we spend some time with them, like 20% of time of FTE, no matter if it was assisted or not, to keep close.

Client 00:09:05

How did you define how much you could charge for this discovery piece?

Expert 00:09:11

We did some market research, and we basically were also assessing what are the rates of Big Four, and we landed in this place with some mindset of experimenting with putting price higher and higher. Since we were in seed, we were trying to get some customers in to get some insight and build the product better.

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Client 00:09:30
How did you charge in the end then, per seat? Did you charge just the platform license per year for everyone to use?

Expert 00:09:38
Just the platform.

Client 00:09:40
It was an overall access to a platform for everyone in your team, and you can map as many workflows as possible, or was that metered of per workflow you pay £10?

Expert 00:09:50
We started, you can map as much as possible, and then we put some cap to it in case they would use it extensively. I think the evolution is in the direction of a process map count, not the user-based count, because you don't want to limit company to not map the whole company. It gives you the visibility, and they also store it on our platform, which is good. One more thing, what worked really well from the beginning was a partnership collaboration. We built partnerships first with some implementation companies in the business which already had access to clients, and they already knew the processes.

Later on, we had some collaboration with Big Four and McKinsey, BCG, where they saw the potential in the tool to be able to map faster. They saw it's a nice angle how we can enhance our team to build. We did some deals where we went together to the company, and we were collaborating and making the proposal together.

Client 00:10:46
What would a typical 500-people business pay for your tool on an annual basis?

Expert 00:10:51
I think, eventually 200,000 yearly.

Client 00:10:54
For just the process mapping?

Expert 00:10:56
Oh, for process mapping. I think 60,000-100,000 yearly.

Client 00:11:03
For process mapping. Why 200,000? Because then you build the agents, or?

Expert 00:11:10
Yeah. We were also selling the platform by itself. Some companies already were ready to use it. Some companies even were ready to use it on their own so we were not the one building it which is the end goal. For some initial collaboration, I think the deal size were around 100,000-300,000 yearly.

Client 00:11:33
You would have a discovery module that you could roll out for 50,000, 60,000, where everyone can map their processes. You have a bit of a service element to handhold and then you pick off use cases, and from these use cases that you pick off, you then have again a platform subscription for people to use these use cases. It would be similar that you have a core platform fee per seat, and then running per use case, or how would that second bit be structured?

Expert 00:12:01
Originally, we were experimenting as anyone with the subscription per team with some capped amount of flows you can automate, but it was high enough to be able to drive adoption in the team. We were charging per team per country. The company can choose to automate one team, and they had good visibility, what are the costs. I have seen also some pricing in a way that you pay for one agent doing the work some monthly fee, so you can replicate the human, so you can associate the cost. Eventually, we move out to price per executed process. It is not price per token, but it is price per executed workflow. Run.

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Client 00:12:43
Yeah.

Expert 00:12:44
Not even a run, because workflow can have multiple runs. Because it's multiple agents collaborating on the workflow, but price per workflow. Basically, you knew that if I have a promo management process, the promo management process costs me one run this, and I know how many people used to work on it, so I can attribute the value.

Client 00:13:06
Yeah, makes sense. That's super helpful. It's every execution gets you closer to the outcome that you want, and the execution costs money effectively.

Expert 00:13:18
Exactly. I'm seeing it in the space as well, you want to get to a space where you charge outcome-based pricing, so you can touch higher margins than as a software. You want to be service-based company charging for outcomes.

Client 00:13:32
If you could just recap a second. You mentioned you have a platform fee, and then the per executions.

Expert 00:13:40
Originally, we had the platform fee and then switched to only workflow-based.

Client 00:13:46
No platform access at all. Everyone in the company could go onto the platform, and the only thing that would matter is when they run executions.

Expert 00:13:56
Yeah. There were some add-ons in terms of support from our side, from FTEs, then some more enterprise features if you wanted to do some security hosting and stuff.

Client 00:14:07
From a pricing perspective, how do you meter these executions as to how many tokens they are using on your side? How do you price an execution? Is it generalistically priced as one execution, or is it like a high complexity, a medium complexity, low complexity execution, for instance?

Expert 00:14:27
No, we decided to go with just one price per execution. It has pros and cons. People might game to automate only higher leverage processes. This is the current state. I think in the future there will be some combination of platform fee and price per workflow, and then maybe based on the difficulty you can have different rates for the workflow. For the simplicity, you don't want to make it more complicated in this stage of the company.

Client 00:14:59
Agreed. That's helpful. What was the rough amount that you would then charge per workflow for now or per execution?

Expert 00:15:07
I think it was in some units of dollars, like higher cents, lower dollars.

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Client 00:15:14
You just had to meter everything.

Expert 00:15:16
Yeah.

Client 00:15:18
Makes sense. Moving back slightly, what were the use cases that or the workflows that have mostly been built and/or that you've sold the most? Because you've done discovery across organizations, so you could have discovered everything? Regardless of FMCG company. Where did you see most of the businesses coming up with stuff **that then also had high usage**? Because there's lots of use cases people think that are important, but then that's not necessarily the things that people are using. What you are arguably looking to do is find something that people are executing a lot because it has value.

Expert 00:15:55
You want to either reduce costs or increase the revenue. Eventually you want to increase the EBITDA. Either reduce the cost or increase the revenue, or you need to reduce the risk. Originally we focus on reduce the cost. We picked the teams which have a lot of people, and we were trying to replace the people by automating the processes. You focus on teams like commercial, where you need to do a listing of products, promo management and stuff. This is something which is being done by a lot of people, or in supply chain ordering products, or eventually in finance doing some dunning and stuff. We moved to some value-based approach. We basically were trying to capture the revenue which the company was not capturing today.

For example, **the dunning process was a good one because people are not able to chase on scale** the suppliers so you can get some money in or increasing the margin by being able to properly nominate the products to the promotion. We were helping teams to reduce time of the month-end by automating certain stuff.

Client 00:17:06
There is a lot of different use case and different angles. Growing the organization, **cutting costs**, efficiency, whatever. What has landed best as the first two, three things to show value quick, but have enough complexity? If you had a new business now in front of you, where would you go hunt, and why?

Expert 00:17:26
I would go either to supply chain. Why? Because usually supply chain in the company is underdeveloped, and you can increase the availability of products quite well because a lot of people are doing forecasting manually or ordering manually. Just having agent who orders everything every day increases availability significantly. That's the first one. The second one, I would say, is finance and doing some invoice processing and doing some back office handling in the company, because SSC is usually super large in the companies, and they do very repetitive stuff.

Client 00:18:04
Does finance matter to the CEO?

Expert 00:18:07
It usually matters to CFO and CEO based on the costs.

Client 00:18:13
And/or how quick to get the numbers and have an overview of what the business is actually doing.

Expert 00:18:18
Exactly. The last one is master data correction. In retail, **you have a lot of messy master data of products coming across the whole organization, which is affecting efficiency** a lot of departments. Being able to correct them or enrich them at the beginning will **save you** a lot of money in operations, supply chain, and stuff.

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Client 00:18:41

Makes sense. The second bit, we talked a lot about pricing, but pricing is a function of experimenting over time. Pricing ultimately is, what people are willing to pay? How did you discover the budget? What were the questions? What were the pointers that you saw along the way that allowed you to have a reference point of what people could or would be willing to spend for what you had to offer? Again, now I understand, and please correct me if that is wrong, that you evolved into having a discovery platform fee per use cases effectively that you would be sketching, and then you had the core platform plus the use cases you are building, and the usage would be on executions.

Expert 00:19:22

Yeah. For us, it was a bit easier because we were from the business, we knew how much people have and how people usually spend. We were basically asking how many products you have in the business to assess the complexity. We were asking how many people you have in the team, and that will tell you how efficiently they are running the operations. We knew from Rohlik how many people you need to operate a certain amount of SKUs and how much the people cost. We were then able to attribute to it.

I would say that we did some calculations in terms of, this department costs you this, you are running this revenue on this margin. If we will automate this process, it will save you epsilon or generate you that, and we want to have 10% of it. We are trying to deliver 10X value or 5X-10X to justify the value.

Client 00:20:14

Do people have budget set aside for this, or is it always just you have to create the budget, in your experience? If **you have to create the budget, there is always the argument around ROI**, but it is so fuzzy because attribution is still so hard. It is more you working backwards.

Expert 00:20:32

You are right. We learned there are two ways how to touch the budget. The first one is people have some budget, or companies used to have some budget on experimenting with AI. You went to CIO, and they told us how much they have for a year.

Client 00:20:50

Probably you use case discovery stuff.

Expert 00:20:52

Exactly. Or you talk to some manager of the department or some director who is your champion and who wants to bring it to company's POC. They have budget for the services. We are trying to touch the service budget line, because it is easier to procure, usually higher budgets than on softwares and stuff. We were basically having the debate around how much budget do you have for consulting services, and we can work with that.

Client 00:21:19

Okay. Consulting services as in like AI consulting or consulting service as in general business consulting or saying, "Hey, what is your consulting budget to optimize procurement", for instance?

Expert 00:21:32

Yeah. They usually don't have AI budgets for consulting. They have a general consulting budget, so from that.

Client 00:21:41

That makes sense. Very helpful. Number one, would be curious, why did you leave as a founder? What has happened from a business perspective? What is your confidence in the business model generally? What would you do differently?

Expert 00:21:59

I have left because I felt that **I am coming to a burnout** because I was working a lot and I have a family with kids, so I knew that if I would stay in the business, I would not help guys eventually, and you need to work 100% in a startup to be able to succeed. It would not be fair to my founders to stay there and basically not performing 100%. I'm still advising there and be a second voice, but I'm not active there anymore. I am super confident that they will make it. The reason why is that I help to and advise companies, large companies in retail and other segments, and **I just see how there is a big opportunity** to first have something which helps companies to basically understand their operations on scale. **It's still a big problem**.

The second one is I still don't see a really great tool on the market which would do really well orchestration of automation on scale and combine browsing with a direct access. I'm now advising a company what to do, how to implement, and I still don't see companies like

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Anthropic or OpenAI to have solid tools to make this work for the business and orchestrate something on scale. I think if they stay in the retail and FMCG, and they will focus still on a vision of having a tool that the business can use and be able to automate on scale, I think this is something which is still not on the market.

Client 00:23:23

Makes sense. That's helpful. If you started again, what would you do different?

Expert 00:23:29

I think I would not waste that much time to experimenting with different industries and different segments. I would narrow the focus more. From the early stage, I would just say, I do retail, FMCG, and maybe I would focus even more to a specific department and then just build really great product around two, three processes, which will be generic enough then to scale. I think **we've lost at the beginning** a couple of months by figuring this out, before we realized we need to keep the focus narrowed.

Client 00:24:01

Makes sense. From a pricing perspective, what would you do differently there? What would your ideal pricing structure now look like?

Expert 00:24:11

I think flat fee plus price per run makes sense.

Client 00:24:16

Per run or per execution?

Expert 00:24:19

Per execution. Makes sense because I think in a year, the CFOs will start evaluating the ROI of token spend, and they need a good visibility of attributing the price of the AI to some unit of work. If you do something super granular, there is a high chance of the company will cut it off because they will not be able to understand how much you spend per a specific unit of work. You need to be close to that.

Client 00:24:45

How would you differentiate between the discovery and the agentic platform then?

Expert 00:24:50

I feel now the discovery is a stronger piece to communicate. I think eventually what would make sense is you can become a 100 billion company, which is like wrapped into some new era consulting company. I think you can be a new BCG, and have agentic platform to help you go in, discover the processes, and then deploy the agentic automation, teach them, and leave and you get to charge also from the software. I think the future is in companies who are able to transform to some hybrid service company, which is powered by their own product, which is agentic.

Client 00:25:29

To understand from a pricing perspective, now, if you had to spin it up, would you differentiate between discovery and use cases, or would you say platform fee and then you pay per use case sketched, and then per execution, or how would you normally do that? Just thinking about how you would land customers, because **you do not want to overwhelm them with an expensive bill** when they are like, "Hey, I actually just want to build out all of the work that is happening in my organization first."

Expert 00:25:56

I think there needs to be a balance of you need some money to get in, you need to commit them to at least some bundle. I think there is an opportunity to touch higher share when you do a product which is capped. You say, "We do discovery. You need to pay first 60,000, and you can map 20 processes." If you want to map more, there is a price per map process or there are some tiers potentially. You basically get some money in. The same, I would say, is for the agentic platform. You want to have some platform fee, which is no matter of how much you automate, then you want to scale with the adoption.

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Client 00:26:38

That is super helpful. Thank you so very much. Anything I should have asked? Anything looking back that you would do different? Anything you wish you knew three years ago, or whenever you guys started?

Expert 00:26:51

I think we could have spent more time with less design partners. We were trying to get sales motion pretty fast, and if we would spend more months with two, three design partners and better understand the operations, **we would be more efficient than in the momentum of scaling**. In general, the more clients you have with different requirements and the more people need to focus on different clients, then **you are losing some efficiency** in moving fast. You want to stay as focused as possible for as much time as possible, and then once you figure it out, you scale faster.

Client 00:27:25

Agreed. Thank you very much. That was extremely helpful, and wish you a happy Friday. I may follow up with questions, but that was helpful already. Thanks.

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